TatvaSoft

SOFTWARE DEVELOPMENT · GUIDELINE

TVS-DEV-AI-GL-01.3

Mandatory AI Usage Guidelines

These are non-negotiable, regardless of which AI tool a team uses or how much trust that team has already built up.

VERSION	EFFECTIVE DATE	PREPARED BY	APPROVED BY
1.0	28.09.2026	Dipal Patel	Shital Patel

HOW TO READ THIS DOCUMENT

Short on time? Read the **Per-Project Setup** checklist — it is required before AI is used on a repository for real changes.

Project AI Configuration is grouped by priority — **Mandatory, Recommended, Nice to have** — with What, Why and an Example for each item.

Parent guideline: **TVS-DEV-AI-GL-01 AI Development Tools Guidelines** (Mandatory AI Usage Guidelines section).

Document Control

Document Control Information

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Document Definition

They exist specifically to stop the failure mode where an AI-assisted change lands in some places and silently misses connected ones — not to police developers, but to make it safe to encourage, upskill, and educate them toward broader AI use.

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Introduction

NON-NEGOTIABLE

These are non-negotiable, regardless of **which AI tool** a team uses or **how much trust** that team has already built up.

They exist specifically to stop the failure mode where an AI-assisted change lands in some places and **silently misses connected ones** — not to police developers, but to make it safe to **encourage, upskill, and educate** them toward broader AI use.

Who	Responsibility
Tech leads	Enforce them at **PR review**
Senior Managers	Audit compliance **quarterly**

Per-Project Setup

Before AI is used on a repository for **real changes**:

	Requirement	Details
☐	**A repo-level rules/context file exists**	e.g. `AGENTS.md` / `CLAUDE.md`: architecture overview, conventions, and known landmines — **mandatory for every repo, before anything else on this list.**
☐	**A code knowledge graph is built for legacy/tightly-coupled repos.**	**Mandatory** for any project flagged legacy or maintenance; **optional (but recommended)** for greenfield projects with few hidden couplings.
☐	**At least one team member is the named AI champion** for that repo	Responsible for keeping the rules file current and flagging new landmines as they're found.
☐	**A sandboxed branch or repo exists**	For low-stakes experimentation, separate from where production changes are reviewed.
☐	**Every developer completes a short AI terminology primer** (agent, skill, MCP, rules, knowledge graph)	Most day-to-day AI use today stops at simple chatbot Q&A, which leaves the other three ecosystem layers unused.

Project AI Configuration

What to build in the repo, **grouped by priority** — what it is, why it's needed, and a real example for each.

MANDATORY	*Required before AI touches real work on this repo* • CLAUDE.md / AGENTS.md • CI / PR template config • Knowledge graph index
RECOMMENDED	*Build next, high value once the mandatory floor is in place* • skills/*.md • agents/*.md • mcp.json • docs/ (README, ARCHITECTURE.md) • hooks/*.md (.claude/hooks.json)
NICE TO HAVE	*Adds polish, not blocking, useful once the basics are working* • commands/*.md • ai-change-log.md

Mandatory

Required before AI touches real work on this repo.

CLAUDE.md / AGENTS.md	
What	Root instructions file the AI reads at the start of every session.
Why	Without it, AI guesses your conventions — the top cause of **"works, but wrong"** changes.
Example	"Never edit tax logic without updating the audit-log module" — catches connected changes before they're missed.

CI / PR template config	
What	A PR template plus a CI check that enforces the guardrail checklist before merge.
Why	A checklist enforced by CI **can't be skipped under deadline pressure** — one living only in a doc can.
Example	GitHub Actions blocks the merge if the PR is missing its impact-radius note.

Knowledge graph index	
What	A pre-built map of symbols, calls, and imports the AI queries instead of guessing.
Why	This is what actually catches **"3 changed, 2 missed"** — text search alone misses indirect coupling.
Example	Graphify/Graphiti indexing a legacy billing module so "what calls this" is a lookup, not a 20-minute search.

Recommended

Build next, high value once the mandatory floor is in place.

skills/*.md	
What	Documented, reusable playbooks for tasks the team repeats often.
Why	Stops the same task being done differently depending on who — or which AI session — runs it.
Example	A shared "add a field and propagate it" skill that always includes the knowledge-graph lookup step.

agents/*.md	
What	Definitions for narrower, specialized AI roles instead of one generalist assistant.
Why	A dedicated impact-analysis role is more reliable than trusting a generalist to remember to check.
Example	A PR-reviewer subagent that only checks diffs against the guardrail checklist.

mcp.json	
What	Connects the AI to real systems — Git, Jira, CI, databases — via the Model Context Protocol.
Why	Lets AI act on **live project state** instead of guessing from stale, copy-pasted context.
Example	An MCP link to Jira so AI pulls the actual acceptance criteria for a ticket.

docs/ (README, ARCHITECTURE.md)	
What	The project's existing human-written architecture notes and decision records.
Why	Gives AI — and new hires — the **"why"** behind decisions that code alone doesn't explain.
Example	"Payments was split from orders in 2022 for PCI compliance" stops an AI refactor from recombining them.

hooks/*.md (.claude/hooks.json)	
What	Automated checks or actions that fire at defined points — before a tool runs, after a file edit, before commit.
Why	Turns a written rule into something **enforced automatically**, instead of relying on the AI — or a person — to remember it every time.
Example	A pre-commit hook that blocks the AI from committing if the impact-radius note is missing, or auto-runs tests after every AI edit.

Nice to have

Adds polish, not blocking, useful once the basics are working.

commands/*.md	
What	Custom shortcuts that package a common prompt into one reusable command.
Why	Saves re-typing the same detailed instructions for routine, repeated requests.
Example	A "/release-notes" command that drafts notes from PRs merged since the last tag.

ai-change-log.md	
What	A running log of notable AI-assisted changes to the codebase.
Why	Gives an **audit trail** for "what did AI change and why" after an incident.
Example	"AI-assisted refactor of discount logic — reviewed by J. Shah, 4 files touched."

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